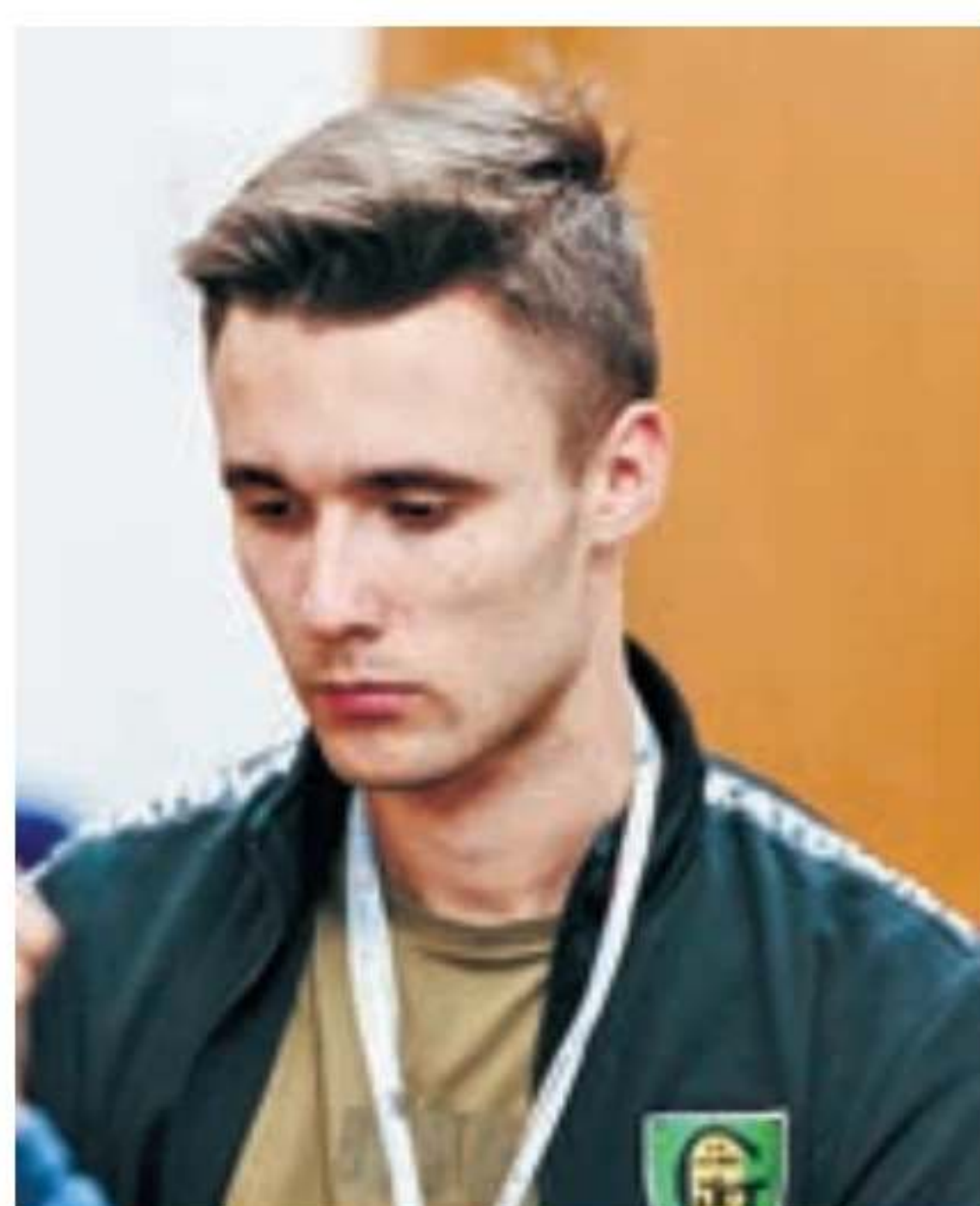




Dream team: (Clockwise from above) Jan-Krzysztof Duda, Jan Klimkowski, Paddy Upton (left), Pentala Harikrishna (centre), Viswanathan Anand, Radosław Wojtaszek and Vincent Keymer. Pics: FIDE

opening preparations. Despite being contemporaries, their collaboration proved to be a vital cog in Gukesh's journey to the World championship title.

"There were mainly two reasons to join this team," Keymer explained in an interaction with *Sportstar*. "First, I felt we had always been friendly, and I believed our chemistry would work well with the rest of the team. Also, I felt that this could be a nice experience. Of course, I was thinking about the learning process this stint would give me because we were working on a very high level for a long time."

Their alliance began in a uniquely personal way. "It was Gukesh himself who contacted me, which I found very nice. He could have gone through a manager or trainer, but instead, he reached out directly. It showed his genuine interest in building a team where personal connections mattered," Keymer said. "We had a brief conversation during the Grand Chess Tour, but it was over the phone. Later, we got to talk face-to-face."

It's uncommon — and risky — for a player to choose a coeval as their Second, given the possibility of revealing strategic ideas that might be used against them in the future. But Gukesh saw things differently.

"Clearly, his main focus was on this World championship," said Keymer. "He wanted to win this match and, since I wasn't involved in either the Candidates or the Championship match otherwise, I don't think there was any direct competition. Of course, long

term that could be possible, but it's very difficult to ask someone to be your Second. You either have players who are still actively playing and have ambitions themselves — and exposing all your ideas, strengths, and weaknesses can have some effect — or, if you don't pick players who are actively playing at the top, then you also have something missing."

Breath of fresh air

Jan Klimkowski, the 17-year-old Polish teenager, was a breath of fresh air.

"It all started with a simple message. He wrote to me, speaking about chess in general, and later left me two positions to analyse. I sent him the files, and he was very satisfied with my work and offered me the job," Klimkowski recalled.

Joining the team after the first rest day, Klimkowski's task was clear: provide Gukesh with innovative ideas and precise opening analysis. "I was playing a tournament in Menorca earlier, so I couldn't do two things at the same time. Once on board, my focus was on preparing specific lines for Gukesh's upcoming opponents," he said.

The young Second put in gruelling hours, often working six to seven hours daily and waking up at odd hours to fine-tune positions. His

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